A Restless Soul

In the second half of the sixties, the German Democratic Republic's search for international acceptance took on new momentum. In February 1965, Ulbricht scored a notable propaganda success in Egypt when greeted with a 21-gun salute and – much to his delight – paraded slowly through Cairo in an open limousine to the cheers of thousands. After a magnificent state dinner, lubricated by fine Egyptian liquors, the First Secretary was awarded the Great Collar of the Order of the Nile by Egyptian President Gamal Abdel Nasser. In foreign policy, Ulbricht attempted to strengthen the GDR's global presence by establishing contact with international organisations and setting up new trade missions. He donated DDM16 million to Castro's regime in Cuba (which recognised the GDR a year later), as well as exchanging general consulates with Iraq. At the same time, preparations were made to accept 1,200 students from countries including Nigeria, India, Iraq and Syria at vocational training schools in Berlin and Leipzig. The GDR was also busily preparing to apply for UN membership which, when submitted in early 1966, was rejected, proving the road to international recognition was rockier than expected.

Meanwhile, the new winds from the Kremlin started to affect Soviet policies in East Berlin. Brezhnev thought little of Ulbricht's reforms and rejected any socialist experiments in his sphere of influence. At a dramatic SED politburo session during July at the Baltic islet of Vilm, old hands lamented the loss of personal ambitions and mourned for the scores of long-serving lesser-rank party officials pensioned off and replaced with younger educated men. Experts at the Institute for Marxism-Leninism, for example, where SED party ideology was formed, had been sent packing and those lucky enough to keep their jobs carped that the Party's absolute claim to authority was in danger, a view shared by Honecker who embarked on a course of confrontation with Ulbricht that was initially covert but later increasingly visible. From here on, he opposed his boss in three policy areas: on German-German relations, on cultural matters and on economic policy. It is certain his opposition didn't spring from any lofty inner